Benoni Defense

ECO A40-A79 | 66 named lines | King's Indian / Grünfeld / Benoni family

In one sentence: Let White build a big center and attack it: dynamic, double-edged and rich in attacking chances for Black.

Memory pattern: Fianchetto, castle, ...e5, ...f5: attack White's king while White attacks yours.



Main line: 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.e4 g6 7.f4 Bg7

Key ideas

1. Black fianchettoes, castles, then strikes with ...e5 or ...c5.
2. Classical KID: after d5 the center locks; White plays on the queenside (c5), Black on the kingside (...f5-f4, ...g5).
3. Grünfeld: Black attacks the center with ...d5, ...Nxd5 and ...c5.
4. Benoni: asymmetrical; Black plays ...b5, ...Re8 and ...Nbd7.
5. The g7 bishop becomes a monster when the center closes.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.83** (clearly better for White, depth 18). Best: Bb5+.

The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Hypermodern: Black fianchettoes and lets White build c4/d4/e4. KID: locked centre (d5/e5) with ...f5 against c5. Grünfeld: Black attacks the centre with pieces and ...c5. Benoni: asymmetrical with queenside majority.
2. Where does my king go?	Black castles kingside and attacks it with pawns (...f5, ...g5) or keeps it solid; White often castles long to counter.
3. Best minor pieces?	Black: Bg7 (the monster), knights e8/d7/c6, rooks f8/e8. White: Be3/Bg5, Nf3, Qd2, space.
4. Main middlegame plan?	KID: ...e5 and ...f5 kingside play against White's c5/queenside space. Grünfeld: attack d4 with ...c5/...Nc6/...Bg4.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants space and a queenside break; Black wants a kingside pawn storm or a central counterblow.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.e4 g6 7.f4 Bg7

Move	Why it is played
1. d4	Center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... Nf6	Develops the knight to f6.
2. c4	Space. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
2... c5	Benoni or Grunfeld break.
3. d5	Gain space. Occupies the center with a pawn.
3... e6	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
4. Nc3	Develops the knight to c3.
4... exd5	Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.
5. cxd5	Grunfeld exchange. Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.
5... d6	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
6. e4	Big center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
6... g6	Fianchetto. Gains space on the wing.
7. f4	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
7... Bg7	Long diagonal. Fianchetto: the bishop takes the long diagonal.



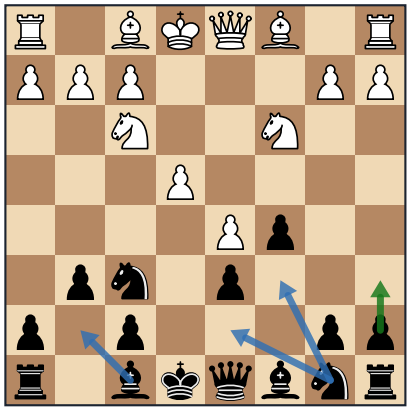
After 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5



After c5 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

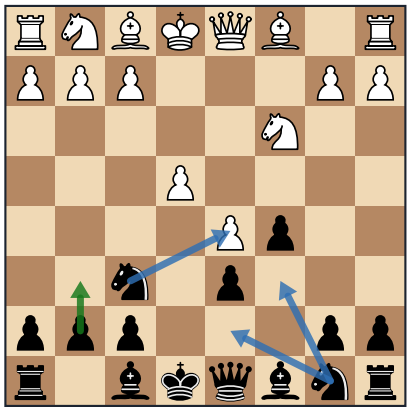


Position after the line

Classical Variation A70 | 13 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 c5 4.d5 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.Nc3 g6 7.e4`

Stockfish: **+0.59** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: a6.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)
Sub-variations: Czerniak Defense, New York Variation, Traditional Variation, Averbakh-Grivas Attack

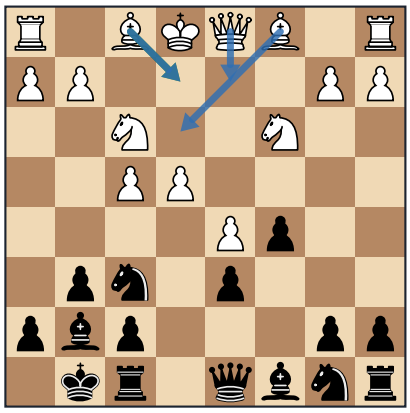


Position after the line

King's Pawn Line A65 | 9 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.e4`

Stockfish: **+0.78** (clearly better for White, depth 18). Best next move: g6.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)
Sub-variations: with Bg5, with Nge2, with Be3



Position after the line

Four Pawns Attack A68 | 6 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.e4 g6 7.f4 Bg7 8.Nf3 O-O`

Stockfish: **+0.27** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: Be2.
What to look for: d4 (center); c4 (space); Nc3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Main Line



Position after the line

Fianchetto Variation A61 | 4 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 c5 4.d5 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.Nc3 g6 7.g3`

Stockfish: **+0.32** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: Bg7.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)
Sub-variations: Hastings Defense

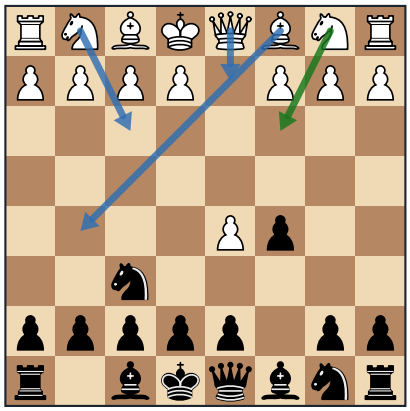


Position after the line

Zilbermints-Benoni Gambit A43 | 3 lines

`1.d4 c5 2.b4`

Stockfish: **-0.49** (slightly better for Black, depth 15). Best next move: cxd4.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)
Sub-variations: Tamarkin Countergambit



Position after the line

Benoni-Indian Defense A43 | 2 lines

`1.d4 c5 2.d5 Nf6`

Stockfish: **+0.62** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: Nc3.
What to look for: d4 (center); c4 (space); Nc3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Kingside Move Order

Detailed repertoire notes

Modern Benoni (A60-A79, Black)

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1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.e4 g6 7.Nf3 Bg7 8.Be2 O-O 9.O-O Re8 10.Nd2 Na6 11.f3 Nc7
12.a4 b6 13.Nc4 Ba6
```

Idea: Play ...e6/...c5 to get a queenside majority and active pieces versus White's central space.

Structure: White has an e4-d5 center and a kingside majority; Black has a 3-v-2 queenside majority and the d6 and e5 squares.

Pieces: Bg7 and rook e8 pressure e4; knights c7/a6, ...b5 break, ...Bf5/g4 for activity.

Plan: Prepare ...b5 and ...Nc7, trade the pieces that guard e4, and use the open g7 diagonal.

King: Castle kingside; watch e4-e5, play ...Re8 and ...Nbd7. **Opponent:** The e4-e5 break, Bb5+, and restraining your queenside pawns.

Watch out: White's e4-e5 break and Bb5+ lines are sharp; know your move orders.

Expert and coach view

Fischer and Kasparov used the King's Indian Defense as a main weapon.

What a coach would tell you

Learn the KID by structure: in the Classical, count the pawn storm race; in the Sämisch, the structure is different (...c5). Make sure you know your plan versus Bg5, h3 and f3 setups.

Why play it

Let White build a big center and attack it: dynamic, double-edged and rich in attacking chances for Black.

Typical mistakes

- Pushing ...f5 before development is complete.
- Allowing White's c5 break without counterplay.
- Playing ...exd4 too early and giving White an easy central grip.

Typical tactics and traps

- Bg5 and Bxf6 followed by Nd5 when Black's knight leaves f6.
- Early e5 pushes by White hitting the unprotected d6 pawn.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Middlegames are sharp; endgames are less common, but a solid pawn structure and open g7 bishop help Black.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Benoni Defense (all lines)** — A56
  `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5`
  - **Old Benoni** — A43
    `1.d4 c5`
    - **Mujannah Formation** — A43
      `1.d4 c5 -> 2.d5 f5`
    - **Schmid Variation** — A43
      `1.d4 c5 -> 2.d5 d6 3.Nc3 g6`
  - **Benoni Gambit Accepted** — A43
    `1.d4 c5 2.dxc5`
  - **Zilbermints-Benoni Gambit** — A43
    `1.d4 c5 2.b4`
    - **Tamarkin Countergambit** — A43
      `1.d4 c5 2.Nf3 cxd4 3.b4 e5`
  - **Benoni Gambit** — A43
    `1.d4 c5 2.dxc5 Na6`
    - **Schlenker Defense** — A43
      `1.d4 c5 2.dxc5 Na6`
  - **Benoni-Indian Defense** — A43
    `1.d4 c5 2.d5 Nf6`
    - **Kingside Move Order** — A43
      `1.d4 c5 2.d5 Nf6 -> 3.Nf3`
  - **Cormorant Gambit** — A43
    `1.d4 c5 2.dxc5 b6`
  - **Snail Variation** — A43
    `1.d4 c5 2.d5 Na6`
  - **Benoni-Staunton Gambit** — A43
    `1.d4 c5 2.d5 f5 3.e4`
  - **French Benoni** — A43
    `1.e4 e6 2.d4 c5 3.d5`
  - **Czech Benoni Defense** — A56
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 -> 3.d5 e5`
  - **Hawk Variation** — A43
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3 c5 3.d5 c4`
  - **Hromádka System** — A56
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 -> 3.d5 d6`
  - **Modern Variation** — A60
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 -> 3.d5 e6`
    - **Snake Variation** — A60
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6 -> 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 Bd6`
  - **Semi-Benoni** — A44
    `1.d4 c5 2.d5 e5 3.e4 d6`
  - **Weenink Variation** — A56
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 -> 3.dxc5 e6`
  - **Woozle** — A43
    `1.d4 c5 2.d5 Nf6 3.Nc3 Qa5`
  - **King's Indian System** — A56
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 -> 3.d5 e5 4.Nc3 d6 5.e4 g6`
  - **King's Pawn Line** — A65
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 -> 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.e4`
    - **with Bg5** — A65
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 Bg7 4.e4 d6 5.f3 O-O 6.Bg5 c5 7.d5`
    - **with Be3** — A65
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.e4 -> 6...g6 7.f3 Bg7 8.Be3`
    - **with Nge2** — A65
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.e4 -> 6...g6 7.f3 Bg7 8.Nge2`
  - **Classical Variation** — A70
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 c5 4.d5 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.Nc3 g6 7.e4`

- **Averbakh-Grivas Attack** A71
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 c5 4.d5 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.Nc3 g6 7.e4 -> 7...Bg7 8.Bg5
- **New York Variation** A70
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 c5 4.d5 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.Nc3 g6 7.e4 -> 7...Bg7 8.h3
- **Traditional Variation** A70
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 c5 4.d5 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.Nc3 g6 7.e4 -> 7...Bg7 8.Be2
- **Main Line** A73
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.e4 g6 7.Nf3 Bg7 8.Be2 O-O 9.O-O
- **Czerniak Defense** A76
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.e4 g6 7.Nf3 Bg7 8.Be2 O-O 9.O-O Re8
  - **Tal Line** A77
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.e4 g6 7.Nf3 Bg7 8.Be2 O-O 9.O-O Re8 -> 10.Nd2
- **Full Line** A74
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.e4 g6 7.Nf3 Bg7 8.Be2 O-O 9.O-O a6 10.a4
- **Argentine Counterattack** A75
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 c5 4.d5 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.Nc3 g6 7.e4 -> 7...Bg7 8.Be2 O-O 9.O-O a6 10.a4 Bg4
- **Fianchetto Variation** A61
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 c5 4.d5 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.Nc3 g6 7.g3
  - **Hastings Defense** A63
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 c5 4.d5 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.Nc3 g6 7.Bg2 Bg7 8.Nf3 O-O 9.O-O Nbd7
    - **Main Line** A64
      1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 c5 4.d5 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.Nc3 g6 7.Bg2 Bg7 8.Nf3 O-O 9.O-O a6 10.a4 Nbd7 11.Nd2 Re8
- **Knight's Tour Variation** A61
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 c5 4.d5 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.Nc3 g6 7.Nd2
- **Pawn Storm Variation** A66
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 -> 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.e4 g6 7.f4
- **Uhlmann Variation** A61
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 c5 4.d5 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.Nc3 g6 7.Bg5
- **Franco-Sicilian Hybrid** A40
  1.d4 e6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 exd5 4.cxd5 d6 5.Nc3 g6 6.e4 Bg7 7.Nf3 Ne7
- **Mikenas Variation** A66
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 -> 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.e4 g6 7.f4 Bg7 8.e5
- **Taimanov Variation** A67
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 -> 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.e4 g6 7.f4 Bg7 8.Bb5
- **Four Pawns Attack** A68
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 -> 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.e4 g6 7.f4 Bg7 8.Nf3 O-O
  - **Main Line** A69
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6 6.e4 g6 7.f4 Bg7 8.Nf3 O-O -> 9.Be2 Re8

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

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1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 c5 3.d5 e6 4.Nc3 exd5 5.cxd5 d6
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Plan chain

White	d4 -> c4 -> Nc3 -> e4 -> Nf3
Black	Nf6 -> g6 -> Bg7 -> d6 -> O-O

Three rules to remember

1. Fianchetto, castle, ...e5, ...f5: attack White's king while White attacks yours.

2. KID: ...e5 and ...f5 kingside play against White's c5/queenside space. Grünfeld: attack d4 with ...c5/...Nc6/...Bg4.

3. White wants space and a queenside break; Black wants a kingside pawn storm or a central counterblow.

Pawn structure in one line

Hypermodern: Black fianchettoes and lets White build c4/d4/e4. KID: locked centre (d5/e5) with ...f5 against c5. Grünfeld: Black attacks the centre with pieces and ...c5. Benoni: asymmetrical with queenside majority.